

COVISHIELD CAVALCADE
Drive-in vaccination kiosk in Ahmedabad, May 27, 2021

REUTERS

▼ **IN HINDSIGHT**

WHAT WE DID NOT KNOW THEN

K. SRINATH REDDY
Former Member, Technical Taskforce for Covid-19

- The virus spread not just by droplets, but mostly by aerosols. Use of face masks should have been advised early
- Superspreader events should have been avoided. The Delta wave was devastating because the variant travelled with people and celebrated with crowds
- Predictions based on linear models were inaccurate, did not anticipate the complexity of virus evolution, health system response and people's willingness to accept advisories
- While vaccines reduced the severity of illness, the virus could still infect vaccinated persons because the respiratory tract lacked mucosal immunity
- 'Herd immunity' was a misleading notion: people with acquired immunity in a group only blocked transmission to non-immune persons in that group. Non-immune individuals going to a place with low acquired immunity remain vulnerable to infection



▲ Jan. 10, 2022

> **We knew we had to get things done in record time. That was the only thing at the back of my mind. My team of 8,000 people worked tirelessly**
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> **ADAR POONAWALLA**
> *CEO, Serum Institute of India*

> **Young entrepreneurs need to do this kind of breakthrough stuff. India should stand for innovation. Just copying drugs made by others will not help**
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> **DR KRISHNA ELLA**
> *Executive Chairman, Bharat Biotech*

But nothing had prepared India for the brutal Delta summer in 2021, when suddenly the country found itself running short of hospital beds, ventilators, oxygen cylinders and other medical equipment. The wave accounted for nearly half the pandemic casualties in India.

Meanwhile, India joined the worldwide race for a vaccine. The task before it was not just to find a suitable candidate, but also to administer it to a nation of 1.4 billion people. Eventually, India won the war, but not before it lost 533,847 people, the unofficial count far higher. The world is breathing easier since, but after an experience it will never forget. ■